

not be attacked at a single point. Shutting such systems down, even by court order, would be difficult because they are decentralised and do not belong to any particular company. Unlike Audiogalaxy, iMesh or any of the other similar systems, no central point links people together and serves as an index to all of their files and searches.

Despite all its pluses, Gnutella's performance during a session is quite flaky. If a client happens to find reliable hosts early, it will obtain a steady flow of data. At other times, a client may struggle to find even a single permanent connection. Other alternatives to decentralised server technology include Aimster, which piggybacks on Instant Messaging clients, and Espra, built upon Freenet, a decentralised and anonymous publishing/distribution system.

I will survive

So in the post-Napster era, how do the surviving P2P file sharing programs fare? Here's a round-up of some of the most

Digital Music in India

The Indian music industry works under a different reality, wherein Internet infrastructure and PC penetration aren't widespread enough to cause any noticeable dent in music revenues. Indian music may not be as popular as Eminem's latest single, but a large amount of Indian music is easily available online. Our test run with file sharing applications revealed a large bank of Indian classical music, Bollywood hits and

regional folksongs on Audiogalaxy and P2P applications using Gnutella. Alternatively, you can buy your MP3s online from www.soundbuzz.com, which has tied up with major Indian record labels, independent labels and unsigned artistes to distribute their content online. Credit cards are the default mode of payment as of now, but Soundbuzz is looking at alternate payment methods including ISP and telecom billing.

popular services and a review of what you can expect.



Aimster
www.aimster.com

A decentralised 'plugin' for AOL Instant Messenger, it allows users to view and swap files with those on their

buddy list. The latest version of Aimster allows the user to plug into other file transfer services, including Napster, OpenNap and Gnutella, among others.



Audiogalaxy
www.audiogalaxy.com

This is a browser-based

Music Keyword Search

How good are these surviving services at getting the MP3s you want? We made a test run with four singles belonging to different categories to gauge their effectiveness.

- Popular:** Shakira s Whenever Wherever
- Indian Regional:** Suprabhatam as sung by M.S. Subbalakshmi
- Rare:** John Lennon s Make Love, Not War
- Non-Commercial:** Mc Hawking s Entropy

This is a popular song that's getting a lot of airplay, but is also copyrighted. This would check if the service blocks copyrighted MP3s.

A Tamil bhajan; does the service cover world regional music?

A rare number from The Lost Lennon Tapes. Widely bootlegged since first being aired on a radio show.

An MP3 only release that hit the top position on the charts at mp3.com.

	BearShare	Audiogalaxy	Espra	Morpheus	iMesh	Edonkey
Popular	✓ (67 Results)	✓	✗	✓ (1304 Results)	Not Functioning*	✓ (24 Results)
Indian Regional	✗	✓	✗	✗		✗
Rare	✗	✓	✗	✗		✗
Non-commercial	✓	✓	✗	✓ (10 Results)		✗
Speed						
Accuracy of results						
User base						
OS Support	Windows	Windows, Linux	Windows, Mac, Linux	Windows	Windows	Windows, Mac, Linux

** The latest version of iMesh kept crashing after the registration process*

Conclusion: Although BearShare and Morpheus use the same Gnutella backbone, Shakira's 'Whenever Wherever' gave a different number of search results. This is because each session with Gnutella is variable, and depends on the peer you are connected to.

Espra, based on Freenet is still in the beta stage and many features haven't been implemented yet. Freenet definitely has a long way to go before it becomes popular. It's unfair to judge Edonkey with MP3 file sharing applications—it's primarily used to swap movies and games.

Audiogalaxy still remains the best MP3 downloading application, despite its attempts to filter MP3s. A word of caution: results are not always accurate. You might find a lot of MP3s that don't belong to the original recording artist at all.